

20,000

The number of people marching at an antiwar rally in Washington, D.C., in 1965.

300,000

The number of people at an antiwar rally in the city in 1971.



Flames of protest

Demonstrators wave flaming draft cards at an antiwar protest in New York. This form of protest became more organized and widespread after 22-year-old David Miller was sent to prison for publicly burning his draft card in October 1965.

Early protests

Many antiwar activists had participated in the Civil Rights Movement, in which nonviolent tactics, such as marching and sit-ins, swayed public opinion and lent the movement its moral authority. In the early 1960s, small antiwar demonstrations led by fringe groups, including communists, pacifists, and antinuclear activists, gave way in 1965 to the first mass protest: a march in Washington, D.C. In October 1967, 100,000 demonstrators gathered at the Lincoln Memorial, with more than a third of them also marching on the Pentagon. By this time, protests consisting of tens and even hundreds of thousands of people were taking place in cities around the country, commanding national media attention.

Meanwhile, mass and individual acts of civil disobedience—draft card burnings, induction dissent, and the refusal of those already on active military service to go to Vietnam—led to a spate of legal trials that ensured antiwar protests remained in the headlines.